intelligence? Akbar didn't care. Having put Shamsuddin Ataka in the crosshairs of Maham's resentment, Akbar also recalled Adham Khan from Malwa, thus bringing all the major players in the factions of his ataka and anaka dangerously close to one another.

At this precise moment, however, the greatest threat to his empire's stability was Akbar himself, creating a royal commotion on his musth elephant – his bare feet gripping its harness, a metal goad at its head, while crowds gathered, mouths agape. Shamsuddin took off his turban in agitation, pleading for the padishah to get off. Akbar was disgusted. 'If you don't stop,' he yelled, 'I'll at once throw myself down from the elephant.'[24] A painting of the scene shows Shamsuddin standing with hands raised in helpless prayer, as the boats keeping the bridge afloat slide this way and that under the pounding of elephant feet.[25]

Michael H. Fisher defines 'musth' rather wittily as 'seasonally aggressive behavior associated with testosterone surges in the elephant (and perhaps in the rider as well)'. The nineteen-year-old emperor may have needed release for his stores of energy. And he would not be the first human being to become addicted to danger. Years later, however, Akbar would explain what it was that made him ride musth elephants, the more bloodthirsty the better – elephants that had killed their mahouts and trampled bystanders, elephants that no one dared approach – in very different terms. Akbar did it, he said, because he wanted to know if he had 'taken a step . . . displeasing to God'. Could he have meant that he was no longer interested in the advice of his retainers, nurses and foster fathers, no matter how loving or loyal? He wanted his opinions from God; and if God did not approve of Akbar's actions, well then, 'may that elephant finish us'.[26]

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He 'sought for truth', writes Abul Fazl, '. . . and consorted with every sort of wearers of patched garments such as jogis, sanyasis and qalandars, and other solitary sitters in the dust'. One day, riding out of Agra on a hunt, Akbar came across some 'Indian minstrels . . . singing enchanting ditties about the glories' of their *pir*, the Sufi saint Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti. Enthralled, Akbar declared he would visit the saint's tomb in Ajmer. The trip was completely unplanned and even advised against – presumably since